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# Decolonizing youth development: re-imagining youthwork for indigenous youth futures

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**Abstract**

Drawing on scientific theories of racial supremacy and efforts by Western nations to *develop* uncivilized races, preeminent psychologist G. Stanley Hall proposed that the bio-psychological development of children recapitulated the ancient history of mankind. Utilizing Hall's theory, US youth organizations designed programs for young people to engage corresponding sociological stages. Using archival sources, I document how Hall's theory, and the "playing Indian" programs established from it, secured settler colonialism by marginalizing Indigenous cultures, governance, laws and ideologies and positioning tribal societies as primitive and childlike relics of the past destined to be replaced by modern man and nation. I then introduce the *specter of recapitulation* and how these ideas continue to harm Indigenous communities, and exponentially harm Indigenous youth. Finally, using Ermine's concept of ethical space, I conclude by exploring the space between knowledge systems about youth and presenting possibilities for decolonizing youth development and reimagining youthwork supportive of Indigenous youth futures.

**Keywords**

indigenous youth development, indigenous youth, recapitulation, youthwork

## The white man's burden: a brief history on the dilemma of development

In the 19th century, social scientists began applying Darwin's theories of evolutionary biology to human society, theorizing the emergence of modernity or the "fittest" race (Spencer, 2018). Through this study, often termed *race development*, they began to categorize and classify various cultures or races around the world, arguing that races of people were on an evolutionary path to becoming modern man (Morgan, 1964/1877). American anthropologist Lewis Henry Morgan presented a hierarchy of sociological development that ranged from *savage* to *civilized* (Morgan, 1964/1877). Hiram Price, the United States Commissioner of Indian Affairs agreed with Morgan, declaring that "savage and civilized life cannot live and prosper on the same ground; [o]ne of the two must die" (Price, 1881). English anthropologist, E.B. Tylor, believed civilization was a process of complex evolutionary growth that inevitably resulted in extinction or assimilation of the lower races (1870).

This framework "fetishize[d] western rationality as the pinnacle of development" and rendered peripheral subjects (women, racial others and children) pathological and abnormal (Walkerdine, 1993, p. 451). Non-Western or *savage* societies were cast as intellectually "rude," had a lower level of "moral powers" and their modes of subsistence, government, housing, family and religion were classified as rudimentary (Morgan, 1877, p. 4). Man, in his undeveloped state, was depraved and governed by "animal impulses and desires" (Harris, 1870, p. 181), he had a penchant for intertribal warfare and sexual promiscuity (Engels, 2004) and his life was "essentially devoted to gaining subsistence from nature" (Tylor, 1889, p. 43). His language contained "neither literary nor scientific information" (Macaulay, 1835, p. 3) was not fit "to impart and express the ideas which expand the mind and excite higher aspirations" (McCosh, 1890, p. 16).

Modern, or civilized man on the other hand, was represented as superior. He was highly autonomous from his family and clan, he was a scientific thinker, kept time and "ma[d]e judgments on the basis of objective evidence" (Inkeles, 1975, p. 324). He had a higher level of brain development as indicated by "sustained attention, concentration, analysis [and] abstraction" (Patrick, 1914, p. 476) and showed inhibition over his "primitive impulses" (Wells, 1918, p. 38) and spoke an advanced, Western European language (Heller & McElhinny, 2017, pp. 68-69). Disciplined, monogamous, private property-owning males with civilized habits like punctuality, obedience, orderliness

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and efficiency, reigned as the head of the modern, civilized families (Black, n.d.; Engels, 2004).

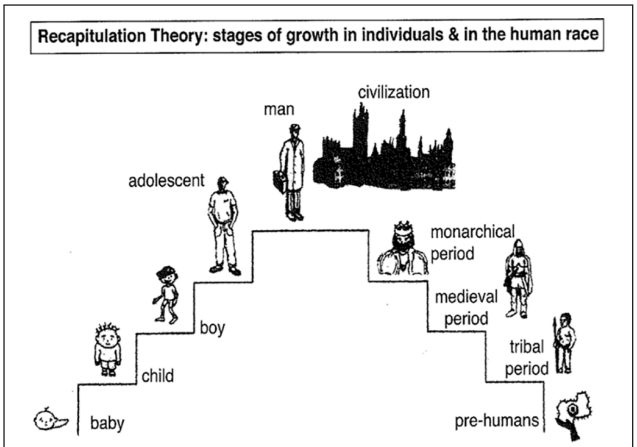
Although hierarchies of race were disputed by some anthropologists at the time (Boas, 1901; Kroeber, 1915), these ideas coalesced into an international phenomenon known as the *White Man's Burden*. Colonial nations used this science to justify policies of imperialism and assimilation for their new acquired *primitive* subjects (Gould, 1977, p. 126). United States Congressman Henry Dawes stated Native Americans must be forced to assimilate to Western norms; "wear civilized clothes, cultivate the ground, live in houses, ride in Studebaker wagons, send children to school, drink whiskey [and] own property." Captain Henry Pratt, founder of the federally-funded Carlisle Indian Industrial School, in his speech better known for the infamous words "Kill the Indian, Save the Man," stated that despite its horrendous conditions, slavery was a "blessing" because Black Americans had been delivered from the cannibalism of Africa . . . "[t]hey became English-speaking and civilized, because [they were] forced into association with English-speaking and civilized people" (Pratt, 1892).

While colonization is rooted in notions of racial supremacy and colonial governments had long been using these ideas to introduce "the habits and arts of civilization" to Indigenous peoples, the science of *Race Development* legitimized and nationalized their efforts. By the turn of the century, the United States had developed an extensive system of day schools, boarding schools (Adams, 1995), family education programs (Cahill, 2011) and industrial schools, which "introduced the concept of forced labor [thus] transforming the ostensibly moral project of civilizing the Indians into a for-profit enterprise" (Grande, 2004, p. 17). School attendance resulted in a loss of identity and trauma. Staff sheared children's hair, changed their names, banned traditional clothing and customs, and coerced conversion to Christianity. They allowed little to no contact with families of origin. Emotional, physical and sexual abuse and death due to illness and/or as a result of corporal punishment was regular (Adams, 1995; Piccard, 2013). The Truth and Reconciliation Commission on Canadian Residential Schools has documented the deaths of more than 6,000 students in boarding schools, which by comparison means it was more likely for a Native child to die in a residential school than for a Canadian soldier to perish in World War II (Schwartz, 2015). These educational practices, brutal by any standard, were ironically and discursively presented as "in the best interest" of the Native child.

## Let's 'play Indian': recapitulation and youth development

"The child revels in savagery" -G. Stanley Hall

At the same time that Native communities were experiencing these "civilizing education" efforts, preeminent child psychologist and "progenitor of adolescence" (Sercombe, 2010, p. 41), G. Stanley Hall, began to draw upon the same theories of racial supremacy



Relationships between primitives and children established in recapitulation theory.

to suggest revision to Ernst Haeckel's biological theory of recapitulation. Hall argued that the course of human evolution was not, as Haeckel proposed, seen in the stages of embryonic development, but in the postnatal development of the individual child's mind (Green, 2015). Children, or perhaps more accurately stated, *White* children's, behaviors, thoughts, and actions recapitulated the primitive instincts and histories of their ancestors. Hall proposed two "staged" developmental trajectories (the race and the individual) which ran *parallel* to one another and collided in the production of civilized man and society[1]. In other words, White boys were the evolutionary equivalent of Indigenous adults. Luther Gulick, a colleague of Hall's wrote that the cooperative play of 12-year-old White boys was comparable to what adult savages achieved "fighting in organized groups under a chief" (1899, p. 142). Like its predecessors, Hall's theory positioned "the Western world [man and culture] as the culmination of all of human progress" (Fallace, 2015, p. 97).

Some contemporaries of the time found Hall's assertions outlandish but with his emergence alongside the Victorian masculinity crisis and a growing anti-modernist movement, his ideas quickly became "relied upon as facts" (Rodeheaver, 1907, p. 15). Psychologists, educators and child studies scholars began to assert recapitulation speculations as universal, scientific truths. "The modern individual begins his career at precisely the same point which each cave-man started" (Wells, 1918, p. 371). The child has "inherited certain tendencies from his ancestry" (Guise, 1914), his play "resembles the pursuits of primitive man" (Patrick, 1914, p. 472). Before our eyes, childhood became a vestige of human's bestial past (Gagen, 2007).

Through Hall's Theory of Recapitulation, a new burden, that of the *adult*, joined the *White Man's Burden.* Hall (1907) urged the child's "proclivities" to be indulged to promote development (p. 2) and educators around the nation were advised not to forget man's animal ancestry; "allow for it . . . during its various stages of development" Dolber, 1900 (cited in Armitage, 2007). Adults must not only play active and supervisory roles for children, but they must "sequence" (Dopp, 1902) or use corresponding

sociological stages as a guide to develop their programming (Armitage, 2007, p. 57; Fallace, 2015, p. 94).

Youth organizations worked urgently to design curriculum built on this idea of parallel development. The Handbook for Scout Masters (Boy Scouts of America, 1913) produced by the Boys Scouts of America, an international organization established in 1910, argued that "understanding the parallelism of boys-life and race-life" would make the Scout Masters work easier. Organizations marked this linear sociological progress with games, names and program stages (westward expansion in the United States became the proxy for the latter stages of European development). For example, in the YMCA's Christian Citizenship program, a young boy would graduate from the *Friendly Indian*s—a curriculum for 8-year-old boys to explore primitive culture and the natural world to become a *pioneer* and eventually a *comrade* or *Hi-Y*—a church and school-based curriculum for adolescents that explored morality, service and US citizenship. The *Friendly Indian* might earn credit by making an Indian implement but to make progress in the program, he must accept the fact that "as civilization advanced," the Indian settled down and assimilated to the new world (YMCA, 1936, p. 20). In the Sons of Daniel Boone, another scouting program established in 1905, names and games reinforced this sociological order. Participants, called *frontiersmen*, played games like the *Hunters and Hunted*, where a captured Indian earned a player "10 points" and *Renegade*, where one boy was assigned the dubious task of playing the "traitorous white man" (Beard, 1909, p. 55).

Child rearing pedagogies, recreation facilities and physical education provisions were all influenced by Hall's theory. The child's educational environment, it was thought, must be free from restrictions and open to play which was somewhat animalistic, "lower-level," and reflexive (Gulick, 1899). The child liked to swing, jump, run, build and play with tools, knifes and bows (ibid); he had limited attachments to his peers, was focused on subsistence and "innately close to nature" (Armitage, 2007, p. 44). Joseph Lee, longtime president of the Playground Association of America was an ardent proponent of what he termed the "big Injun age of childhood development" (Armitage, 2007). His organization alongside the American Physical Education Association[2], would help to establish public playgrounds across the country in an effort to harness these habits of savagery and *evolve* children through play; one park going as far as to provide a "cave men" simulation (Gagen, 2007). By 1915, 14 states required nature study in public elementary schools. Charles Lincoln Edwards, the Director of Nature Study for the Los Angeles Public Schools (California), called for school gardens and field trips to be buttressed with "the stories and songs of negroes and Indians" because "these more primitive people are but grown children, living in closer touch with nature" (Armitage, 2007, p. 52).

In Hall's understanding, as the child progressed into a boy, so too did his natural needs and instincts. He embarked on a brave, new journey to develop beyond primitive survival. His play began to focus on "one's self in relation to others" (Gulick, 1899, p. 140). Boys (as opposed to younger children) developed through physical force, shrewdness and competitive group play. He enjoyed "activities of savage warfare" like fencing and wrestling (Gulick, 1899, p. 140), track and field activities which allowed him to challenge himself against another boy (Rader, 2004) and games like *hide and seek*, which recapitulated "the hunting and gathering skills needed for survival" in primitive life (Clarke, 1999, p. 75).

While the boy retained his innate love of nature, as he aged, he also began to express more tribal instinct. Programs like the Woodcraft Indians, YMCA summer camps, Indian Guides, Boy Scouts and Campfire Girls[3] sought to develop boys and girls by *playing Indian* (P. J. DeLoria, 1998) –mimicking pan-Indian activities like: dressing up in costume, making camp, learning Indian nature lore and enacting tribal ceremonies (Campfire Girls, 1920; Seton, 1907). These programs often borrowed carelessly and at times, simply invented tribal culture and practices (Wall, 2005). Arrival at the program, with its rituals and solemn council circles, transported the participant into the realm of the Indian past. There, boy participants were provided an opportunity to wear breech cloths and face-paint, build teepees and indulge savage instincts through "games of scalping" (Wall, 2005, p. 525). They engaged in the production of Indian crafts like instruments of war and drums (YMCA, 1936, pp. 15-16), identified animals, plants and trees, took Indian names (Seton, 1907), participated in fictitious rites of passage and re-enacted war parties (Boy Scouts of America, 1913). A gender differentiated curriculum was used for girls development with appropriately feminine but "equally native" activities like dancing, singing, learning Indian stories and symbols, crafting baskets, making headbands and ceremonial gowns (Campfire Girls, 1920).

As the boy transitioned to early adolescence, he became increasingly interested in complex team play. The playing Indian motif remained, but shifted from the study of nature (relatively solitary or small group) to the utilization of competition and physical aggression (more interactive or cooperative). Organized team athletics "proved a splendid motive against vice" and it used the boy's gang spirit to develop leadership, masculinity and character required of a civilized man (Hall, 1904, p. 229). As these ideas naturalized, Christian boy's workers (a term popularized by the YMCA but also used by faith-based organizations who worked with young boys) began to envision sport and physical activity as an age-appropriate "form of religious expression" (MacLeod, 1978, p. 17) and a subsequent explosion of sport teams for young people emerged. Teams like the Indians, Warriors, Braves and Redskins were created (an ironically *logical* practice in Hall's schema) to provide an opportunity for boys to develop their latent savage into civilized manhood (Oriard, 2011). The team captain, that boy who exercised "qualities of a high order, analogous to those exercised by a successful chief" would serve as moral exemplar to the others (Gulick, 1899, p. 142).

By the time a boy entered late adolescence his allegiance had passed from the "gang to the hero or chosen leader" (Boy Scouts of America, 1913, p. 97). His development became less physical and increasingly intellectual and

moral and he no longer needed to "play Indian." He experienced what G. Stanley Hall termed *storm & stress*, becoming increasingly rebellious, moody, risky and seeking autonomy from his parents (Arnett, 1999; Hall, 1904). Just as his ancestors broke free from the confines of archaic traditionalism and came to embrace enlightenment and discovery, the adolescent—"an evolutionary product similar to men of medieval times" (MacLeod, 1978) — needed space to vent these instincts. Clubs and Societies for boys, directed and controlled by boys, were encouraged as they could provide a "time and place for barbarism and idiot nonsense" while "advance[ing] altruism and reduc[ing] selfishness" (Rodeheaver, 1907, p. 48). The Young Folks Handbook (American Institute of Child Life, 1913) helped established afterschool clubs evoking medieval legends. These circles for youth ages 14–25, were "devoted to character-building" moving the adolescent though developmental degrees including: preparation, hero-worship and service. Christian boy ministries, believing that teenage boys were instinctually driven by a need to join their medieval forbearers, utilized the stories and themes of medieval knighthood to develop ideal young men. Programs such as the Knights of King Arthur and Knights of the Holy Grail emerged to produce chivalrous, morally refined and confidently virile "Christian gentleman capable of pursuing refined virtues through manly and aggressive means" (Powell, 1906; Setran, 2010). Even contemporary social gatherings like Homecoming Court and Prom were built from monarchical traditions that aimed to display and reinforce civilized behavior and proper etiquette.

But if White children developed alongside their corresponding sociological stages, then what of the so-called *savage* young person? Hall's theory positioned Indigenous youth as inherently different from and underdeveloped in comparison to their White peers. Native and White children were in need of "distinct and asymmetrical forms of developmental intervention" (Strong, 2009, p. 401). As such, Native youth were largely excluded from mainstream organizations or when they were allowed to participate, they were met with divergent goals. White boys developed strength and character through sport (Naismith, 1941, p. 135) but American Indians were civilized and Americanized (Bentley, 2010; Bloom, 2000). White Campfire girls were encouraged to engage in strenuous physical activity and connect to nature as a challenge to Western gender roles. Native Campfire girls were allowed to perform White-approved versions of Native identity; they could dress in feathers and ceremonial gowns and were even at liberty to study some of their own tribal customs, but they were discouraged when declaring themselves modern or equivalent to their white counterparts and frequently reminded of the necessity of white civilization through the dominant curriculum of the boarding schools who hosted their clubs (Helgren, 2014).

## The specter of recapitulation

Scholars define colonialism in terms of sociohistorical structures which seek to destroy Indigenous peoples to replace them with the colonizer's norms, authority economies and knowledge (Wolfe, 2006; Kauanui, 2016; Tlostanova & Mignolo, 2012). Youth organizations—"a powerful mechanism for crafting and fashioning the self" (Turner Strong, 2009, p. 199) developed and delivered programs and curriculum that established this structure in the United States and beyond. Despite recent efforts to halt "playing Indian" programs or distance themselves from rogue resisters, youth organizations helped construct ideas and identities that cemented settler colonialism and continue to harm Indigenous communities, and exponentially to harm Indigenous youth.

### *Continued erasing and replacing of Indigenous life*

The curriculum of youth development organizations affirmed the dominant erasure of Indigenous life. These curricula simplified intricate systems of Indigenous geographic, ecological, spiritual, astronomical and architectural knowledge, turning them into toys for White children—shoebox dioramas, plant identification badges, make-believe ceremonies, and teepees "picturesque and big enough for half a dozen boys" (Seton, 1907, p. 22). They naturalized settler colonialism as a method of racial progress, "long before the White man came, the Indian held sway in this great land of ours. Then came the White man" (YMCA, 1936, p. 20). Once Indigenous communities were significantly simplified and erased, youth organizations would insert the colonizer's culture, governance, laws and ideologies. Participants were encouraged to promote the new nation's "existence" (Seton, 1907, p. 1), sing nationalist anthems (Campfire Girls, 1920), and participate in council rituals including "pledges of allegiance" to the United States and Christian flags (YMCA, 1936, 13). They were told to do their share of "national and patriotic work" like making friends with immigrant girls to assist in their Americanization (Campfire Girls, 1920, 150).

In the United States, youth development organizations and public education systems remain the primary sources of education and identity building for youth. As such, the narratives that Native and non-Native children internalize must be still be considered. In a nationwide study of history curriculum, Shear et al. (2015) found that Indigenous people largely disappear from state standards by the year 1900, and when they are represented it is often in relation to white settlers and frequently negative: backwards, archaic, violent, and lazy. Science, technologies, and governance of man is presented as the curriculum of modern man encouraging students to arrive at the conclusion that "civilized society ha[s] surpassed the primitive Indian and African ones in a process of linear cultural development" (Fallace, 2015). Upward of 2,000 schools in the United States still utilize Native American mascots despite empirical findings that they have harmful psychosocial effects on Native youth and reinforce stereotypes among non-Native youth (Davis-Delano et al., 2020). Youth organizations continue to reaffirm youth as deficient and not "yet" adult, they normalize adult-designed and facilitated development and promote learning guided by

Western desires, morals and behaviors. These organizations maintain settler colonial identity and political institutions; they marginalize the civic strategies of Indigenous youth and youth of color (Sherrod, 2003; Watts & Flanagan, 2007) and fail to acknowledge Indigenous political status and conceptions of citizenship (Battiste & Semaganis, 2002), calls for decolonization (Tuck & Yang, 2012) and social ignorance of Indigenous sovereignty.

## *Normalizing western middle-class childhood and youthhood*

Youth development organizations also worked to erase and replace specific ideologies and norms of young people, family and kinship (Tlostanonva & Mignolo, 2012). Western worldviews tend to produce a future-oriented, anthropocentric, compartmentalized individualism whereas Indigenous worldviews tend toward holistic, interrelated, and relational communalism. Within each worldview, there are differing values, concepts, roles, norms, rites of passage, pedagogies and responsibilities that the young person experiences (Brendtro et al., 1990; Killsback, 2019). For example, in traditional Dakota communities at the turn of the 20th century, it was considered "an offense" if a Dakota mother explicitly asked her relatives to care for her child (E. C. Deloria, 1944). The kinship system of the Dakota family was communal; it was an honor to care for and be in relation with young people. Young people were represented by words like *wakanyeza* which assumed the sacredness of the young person. This positioned the parent and community as recipient of a gift, not a burden or a piece of property. This extended system promoted an expansive sense of security and created a natural safety net in the instance of parental loss or hardship (Smithsonian, n.d.). Indigenous familial relationships with youth were affectionate, children were "strictly trained but surrounded in a sea of love and kindness" (LittleBear, 2000, p. 81).

Modern-day "normal childhood" is a Western construction (Mintz, 2004). It is an adult-supervised, stridently scheduled time of play and protection, delivered preferably via heterosexual, gender dichotomous, nuclear parents with legal, and biological ownership over the child. The modern-day child develops into Hall's *adolescent*, a biologically determined subordinate of the adult who is driven by a rebellious nature. Adolescence is a time to make mistakes and push boundaries; it affords flexibility for crime, stubborn resistance and rebellious behavior.

But children of color and Indigenous youth are not afforded the same "presumption of innocence as white children" (Patton, 2014). They face systematic disparities in our national institutions. They are more often and more severely discipline in schools (Gregory et al., 2010) and have disproportionate contact with the juvenile justice system (Rodriguez, 2010). Even their bodies are not perceived in the same way; they are less likely than White peers to receive quality medical care and pain management (Sabin & Greenwald, 2012). Fellow citizens routinely overestimate their age and when those over-estimators are police offices, those overestimations are predictive of the use of force (Goff et al., 2014).

The idea of a "normal" modern-day childhood and youthhood with universal experiences, opportunities and desired goals is a charade. In a collision between worldviews (LittleBear, 2000), youth organizations sided with the West. Their values, timelines, goals, languages, program offerings and professional standards are strikingly similar to the boarding schools of a century ago. They not only helped to erase Indigenous childhood, but they replaced it with an undesirable and unachievable WEIRD—Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich and Democratic—childhood (Barone, 2015) masked in false pretense.

## *Confident characteristics*

Over the last century, Hall's construction has "thingified" young people (Baizerman, 1999); marking them as *deviant others* who threatened the supposed "right' culture of society (Griffin, 2013). They are represented by what Lesko (2012) calls *confident characteristics* or commonly held social notions that adolescents biologically embody turn-of-the-century stereotypes of "primitives": irrational, immoral, emotionally uncontrolled, aggressive, hypersexual and lacking autonomy. The science of adolescence has built an empirical literature based on these preconceived notions, routinely eschewing or submerging explanatory social associations in favor of chronological ones (Arnett, 1999; Males, 2009). The reality is that the majority of adolescents are doing "quite well" (Offer & Schonert-Reichl, 1992) and if they do experience trouble, often do so at rates similar to adults (Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, 2018). This science has resulted in a pathologization and subjugation of young people (Sercombe, 2014) which is then legitimated through research, policy and practice (Garrison, 2008).

This research, policy and practice, with the twin assumptions of race and age, is doubly damaging for Indigenous youth. It positions them as an exponential litany of savage characteristics. For decades, scholarship on Indigenous youth has had an almost exclusive focus on their deficits: their risky behaviors, drug and alcohol use, mental health concerns, suicidality and low academic achievement (Beauvais et al., 2004; Borowsky et al., 1999; Cummins et al., 1999). Within the research, the locus of these problems is often identified within the "Indigenous individual or community" (Smith, 2013) while key social and historical contexts are submerged (Tuck, 2009) and a white sample is utilized as the control, invariably identifying difference as problem (Cauce & Gonzales, 1993). Recently, socio-historic contexts such as historical trauma, adverse childhood experiences, poverty or cross-cultural differences have been identified, but the establishment of prevalence rates, associations, protective factors and treatment responses are still the norm. Halting trauma and dismantling the socio-historic structures causing the trauma tend to be briefly discussed or left in the nebulous realm of community response or responsibility (Brockie et al., 2015; Hawkins et al., 2004), but they are rarely the core of the investigation.

## Re-imagining youthwork for indigenous youth futures

If the notion of *development* itself is fundamentally flawed then youth development is a metaphoric house of cards and yet, contemporary youthwork continues to draw on the many tributaries of Hall's theory. As a practitioner of youthwork and educator of youthworkers, I have listened to the stories of colleagues and students and heard their dissonance. The stereotypes and messages we receive about young people don't match the young people we know. The professional education and practices that we learn often feel alienating, deficit-oriented and paternalistic. As a person who experienced "atypical" adolescent development, Hall's notions of development were in my everyday interactions with institutions; a constant reminder of my failure to be "normal" despite my strengths and contributions to family and community. As a community member, mother and relative of Indigenous youth today, the urgency of this struggle is even more pronounced. I witness Hall's legacy silently chipping away at self-esteem, cultural knowledge and political identity, positioning Native youth as "problems" while instilling ambiguous feelings of inferiority and invisibility.

All those who profess relationship with young people and youth workers in specific, must begin to struggle with this legacy. Youthwork that continues to operate within these frameworks furthers colonial ideas of Indigenous youth, even if that is not the intention. To disavow the racist and classist attitudes of the 1800s but continue to use their theories perpetuates their regime of truth (Lesko, 2012). In our best efforts to understand and help, we draw on knowledge and evidence that reiterates the brokenness of our babies instead of harnessing our efforts to dismantle the systems designed to break them.

Heeding Lesko's caution and using Ermine's (2007) concept of ethical space, I have engaged for over 25 years in Indigenous-led organizations, schools and projects and I have sought to understand the distinct histories, knowledge traditions, values, interests and realities in an attempt to reconcile the collision in these worldviews. I have learned about, applied and utilized Indigenous philosophies in my relationships with young people. I have explored the archives of mainstream youth development and unpacked their conceptions. I have experienced dismissal of Indigenous philosophies in dominant spaces (e.g. recognizing youth as full decision-makers in projects or validating their resistance to adult power or systems of assimilation) and likewise, had these ideas validated in Indigenous-led spaces. I have centered the voices and participation of Indigenous youth, actively engaging youth as co-researchers and co-authors in social and institutional change (Johnston-Goodstar, 2013; Johnston-Goodstar et al., 2017, 2019; Johnston-Goodstar & Velure Roholt, 2013). My story is singular but drawing from these personal, professional and intellectual experiences, I humbly propose three possibilities for youthwork that can interrupt Hall's harmful legacy and collectively craft a practice of youthwork supportive of Indigenous youth futures.

My first proposal is to *reveal*, to pause and examine our ideas of youth and youthwork for evidence of Hall's ideology. This examination does not require us to reject all youth development paradigms, Western science or "modern" solutions. It is not intended as a slight to community youthworkers, who in my experience, are often well intentioned, practicing with limited resources, and at times, on the front-lines of trauma and adversity with our youth. Nonetheless, the colonial history of youth development was intricately buried, it was a tool of colonialism, and it constructed ideas about young people that are omnipresent and harmful. Today, we use words like "youth development," "adolescent" and phrases like "teens are risky," "prone to peer-pressure" and "normal childhood" unaware that they are code words for a host of racist and harmful ideas. In our haste to do *something*, we take up these ideas or attempt to tailor mainstream youth development programs at the expense of a deep analysis of their structural and philosophical constructs (Lateef & Anthony, 2018).

Second, I propose to *recover* and *revitalize* tribal youth philosophies. We cannot presume that the "development process is reasonably similar across ethnicity, culture, country" (Ware & Walsh-Tapiata, 2010). Tribal communities had their own understandings of the life course, kinship systems and relationships. If, for example, the "ultimate aim of Dakota life, stripped of accessories, was quite simple: [that] one must obey kinship rules; one must be a good relative" (E. C. Deloria, 1944, p. 25), how can recovering and revitalizing Dakota philosophies help us become better relatives to our young people? This begs us to ask the most basic question: *what were young people called in your tribal language*? Embedded in tribal philosophies of youth and the original instructions are the values, concepts, roles, norms, rites of passage, pedagogies and responsibilities. These provide a roadmap for new (or the recovery and revitalization of ancient) action. Aligning our youthwork practices with these philosophies will allow an engagement with young people that is not predicated on their assimilation and development into White modern man.

Finally, I propose a collective *re-engagement* with youth to center the problem of *colonialism* and all of its contemporary tactics. We must move socio-historic contexts from the margins to the center. Decolonized and Indigenous-informed youth work—is a practice that can "center and privilege Indigenous life, community and epistemology" (Sium et al., 2012, p. 2) and "peek behind" the illusion of colonial permanency to imagine desirable Indigenous futures (Tuck & Yang, 2012; Waziyatawin, 2012). Youth work practices that engage and transform oppressive social contexts *with* young people such as: Youth Participatory Action Research (Cammarota & Fine, 2010), culturally sustaining and revitalizing pedagogies (McCarty & Lee, 2014), ethnic studies curriculum in schools (Dee & Penner, 2017) and sociopolitical development, youth organizing and Indigenous youth activism (Friedel, 2015; Watts & Flanagan, 2007), have shown tremendous potential to interrupt and remedy these

contexts and simultaneously to increase knowledge, capacity and critical hope among young people.

## Conclusion

Over the last 130 years, recapitulation theory and mainstream youth development organizations have constructed a modern, middle-class childhood and adolescence normed on Western philosophies and in service of colonization. This construction conditions white children and society with notions of cultural supremacy. It fortifies confident characteristics which present Native youth and communities as perpetual problems. It creates institutions to forcibly assimilate and enforce this notion of childhood despite history, context and opportunity. It damages Indigenous youth and communities.

But there is always hope and resistance; settler colonialism may have sought, and continues to seek, to eliminate native peoples, but as Kauanui (2016) reminds, this elimination is *not* complete! Children's author Mo Willems once said, "if you ever find yourself in the wrong story, leave." Together, we can de-link our youth and ourselves from the colonialist story of development and modernity (Tlostanova & Mignolo, 2012). We can recover knowledge with and about young people. We can reimagine and relate with them in new and ancient ways. We can watch and support them as they reclaim their rightful roles. While the exact parameters of a decolonized and indigenized youthwork remain to be seen, a process of collective revelation, recovery, revitalization and re-engagement can serve as guide. It will be an honor to join other scholars and practitioners and to walk alongside our young relatives, listen to their wisdom and collectively build a youthwork that depends on their unique existence and supports their future.

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### Notes

1. Figure 1 from Lesko (2012)
2. These organizations are specific to the history of the United States but similar international efforts to establish playgrounds, physical education and scouting can be found. See Gagen, 2007)
3. Some Native American individuals were involved in the sharing of tribal knowledge and traditions to aid in the development of "recapitulation-based" programming, most notably Charles Eastman (Woodcraft Indians, Campfire Girls), Ella DeLoria (Campfire Girls, YMCA), and Joe Friday (YMCA Indian Guides). Detailing their motivations is beyond the scope of this paper but it is important to note that they presented Indigenous knowledge as real and virtuous. They used the institutions themselves to "talk back to civilization" (Turner Strong, 2009), subversively re-appropriate banned knowledge (Helgren, 2014) and reshape popular conceptions of Native Americans (E. C. DeLoria, 1998, p. 122). This is in direct contrast to their Euro-American counterparts who may have shared some anti-modernist ideas about Western civilization but supported Hall's theory, its child-as-primitive comparison & settler colonial actions.

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